Open Handbook: Digital Literacy

A Practical Guide to Using Technology Wisely

Open Handbook Commons (community-authored)

openhandbook.org

Open Handbook: Digital Literacy

A Practical Guide to Using Technology Wisely

Open Handbook Commons (community-authored)

2026-03-11

Table of contents

Mission 1

License 2

Disclaimers 3

Printing & Binding 4

Contribute 5

Preface 6

I Understanding the Digital World 7

1 What Is Digital Literacy? 8
- 1.1 Definition of Digital Literacy . . . 8
- 1.2 Why Digital Literacy Matters Today . . . 9
- 1.3 How Technology Shapes Everyday Life . . . 9
- 1.4 Digital Literacy vs Computer Literacy . . . 10

2 Types of Digital Devices 11
- 2.1 Desktop and Laptop Computers . . . 11
- 2.2 Smartphones and Tablets . . . 11
- 2.3 Smart Devices and the Internet of Things . . . 12
- 2.4 Choosing the Right Device for Your Needs . . . 12

II Basic Digital Skills 14

3 Operating Systems and File Management 15
- 3.1 What an operating system does . . . 15
- 3.2 Windows, macOS, Linux, Android, and iOS . . . 16
- 3.3 Files, folders, and storage . . . 16
- 3.4 Backups and cloud storage . . . 17

4 Using the Internet 18
- 4.1 How the internet works . . . 18
- 4.2 Web browsers and search engines . . . 18
- 4.3 How to search effectively . . . 19
- 4.4 Understanding websites and URLs . . . 19

5 Communication Online **21**
5.1 Email basics . . . 21
5.2 Messaging apps and video calls . . . 22
5.3 Online etiquette (netiquette) . . . 22
5.4 Managing digital communication . . . 22

III Finding and Evaluating Information **24**

6 Searching for Reliable Information **25**
6.1 Search techniques . . . 25
6.2 Using advanced search tools . . . 25
6.3 Finding academic or trustworthy sources . . . 25

7 Misinformation and Fake News **26**
7.1 What misinformation is . . . 26
7.2 Why false information spreads . . . 26
7.3 How to verify information . . . 26
7.4 Fact-checking tools . . . 26

8 Understanding Digital Media **27**
8.1 Images, videos, and audio online . . . 27
8.2 Manipulated media and deepfakes . . . 27
8.3 Advertising and sponsored content . . . 27

IV Online Safety and Privacy **28**

9 Protecting Your Personal Information **29**
9.1 What personal data is . . . 29
9.2 How companies collect data . . . 29
9.3 Privacy settings and permissions . . . 29

10 Passwords and Account Security **30**
10.1 Creating strong passwords . . . 30
10.2 Password managers . . . 30
10.3 Two-factor authentication . . . 30
10.4 Recognizing suspicious login activity . . . 30

11 Protecting Your Personal Information **31**
11.1 What personal data is . . . 31
11.2 How companies collect data . . . 31
11.3 Privacy settings and permissions . . . 31

V Digital Citizenship **32**

12 Responsible Behavior Online **33**
12.1 Respectful communication . . . 33
12.2 Cyberbullying and harassment . . . 33
12.3 Managing digital conflicts . . . 33

13 Digital Footprints **34**

13.1 What a digital footprint is? . . . 34
13.2 How online posts stay online . . . 34
13.3 Managing your online reputation . . . 34

14 Copyright and Creative Commons **35**
14.1 Ownership of digital content . . . 35
14.2 Using images, text, and media legally . . . 35
14.3 Open licenses and sharing knowledge . . . 35

VI Creating Digital Content **36**

15 Writing and Publishing Online **37**
15.1 Blogs and websites . . . 37
15.2 Basic formatting and structure . . . 37
15.3 Responsible publishing . . . 37

16 Working With Digital Media **38**
16.1 Creating images and videos . . . 38
16.2 Basic editing tools . . . 38
16.3 Sharing media responsibly . . . 38

17 Collaboration in the Digital World **39**
17.1 Online collaboration tools . . . 39
17.2 Shared documents and version control . . . 39
17.3 Working with remote teams . . . 39

VII Digital Skills for Work and Learning **40**

18 Productivity Tools **41**
18.1 Documents, spreadsheets, and presentations . . . 41
18.2 Online learning platforms . . . 41
18.3 Task management tools . . . 41

19 Using Technology for Lifelong Learning **42**
19.1 Online courses and tutorials . . . 42
19.2 Learning communities . . . 42
19.3 Building new skills online . . . 42

VIII The Future of the Digital World **43**

20 Artificial Intelligence and Automation **44**
20.1 What AI is . . . 44
20.2 Everyday uses of AI . . . 44
20.3 Opportunities and risks . . . 44

21 Ethical Use of Technology **45**
21.1 Bias in algorithms . . . 45
21.2 Responsible AI use . . . 45
21.3 Technology and society . . . 45

22 Staying Digitally Literate **46**
22.1 Adapting to new technologies 46
22.2 Continuous learning habits 46
22.3 Teaching digital literacy to others 46

Appendices **47**

A GitHub Contributors **47**

Index **48**

Mission

The Open Handbook Commons is a community-driven project that creates practical books about everyday life skills. Our goal is to make useful knowledge available to everyone, no matter where they live or what their background is.

The books cover simple, practical topics that help people in daily life—things that make it easier to solve problems, learn new skills, and become more independent. All of the books are written in simplified English so that they are easier to read and understand for a wide range of readers, including people who are not native English speakers.

Our books are released as downloadable, print-ready PDF files. This means anyone can read them on a computer or phone, or print them and share them with others.

All content is written, reviewed, and improved by volunteers from the community. Contributors work together to make sure the books are clear, practical, and useful.

The Open Handbook Commons is built on a simple idea: important life skills should be shared openly so that everyone can learn from them.

Check out our complete catalog at https://openhandbook.org.

License

Unless otherwise noted, this book is released under the license:

Creative Commons Attribution–NonCommercial–ShareAlike 4.0 International (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0)

This means you are free to:

- Share — copy and distribute the book in any format.
- Adapt — change, improve, or build on the content.

You must follow these rules:

- Attribution — You must give credit to the original project and mention if you made any changes.
- NonCommercial — You may not use the material to make money.
- ShareAlike — If you modify the content, you must share your version under the same license.

Simple explanation

You are welcome to download the book, print it, and share it with friends, family, schools, or community groups.

However, you may not print and sell the book or produce it in large quantities for commercial purposes unless you receive permission from the project maintainers.

Full legal text: https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-sa/4.0/legalcode

Disclaimers

The information in this book is provided for education, learning, and hobby use only. The content is shared "as is." We do not promise that everything in the book is complete, correct, or suitable for every situation.

The Open Handbook Commons and its contributors are not responsible for any problems, damages, or losses that may happen if someone uses the information in this book. Readers are responsible for making sure that any use of the information is safe, lawful, and appropriate for their situation.

Some parts of the content may be written or edited with the help of AI tools. However, the material is reviewed by community contributors, and errors are corrected when they are found.

The community also works hard to avoid plagiarism and to respect the work of others. Because this is a community project, mistakes can sometimes happen. If you find content that you believe is copied without proper credit or permission, please report it by email at contact@openhandbook.org, and we will review it and take appropriate action.

Printing & Binding

This PDF version of the book is made so it is easy to print at home and bind with spiral or comb binding.

- Paper size: A4 (recommended for most countries)
- If printing on US Letter paper: choose “Fit to printable area” or “Scale to fit”
- Double-sided printing (recommended): select flip on long edge (if your printer supports double-sided printing)
- Binding: spiral or comb binding (the left margin is wider to allow space for binding)

It is a good idea to print one test page first to check that the margins and scaling look correct on your printer.

Contribute

This project is built on community contributions. People can help in many different ways. Some contributions are more technical, such as writing new sections, editing chapters, or helping with the tools used to build and publish the books. Other contributions can be much simpler, such as correcting typos and grammar, checking facts, identifying possible plagiarism, suggesting improvements, or helping make the text clearer.

For more details on how to contribute, please visit our website at https://openhandbook.org.

Preface

Digital technology is now part of everyday life. Many people use computers, smartphones, and the internet every day. We use these tools to communicate with others, learn new things, work, read news, watch videos, and store information.

Because of this, it is important to understand how to use digital technology in a safe, responsible, and effective way. This ability is called digital literacy.

Digital literacy is more than knowing how to use a computer or a phone. It also includes knowing how to find reliable information on the internet, communicate respectfully online, protect personal information, recognize scams and false information, and create and share digital content responsibly.

This book is written to help readers learn these skills. It explains digital tools and ideas in clear and simple language. The chapters introduce common technologies, explain how the internet works, and discuss topics such as online safety, misinformation, and responsible online behavior.

This book is written for students, teachers, self-learners, and anyone who wants to better understand the digital world. No advanced technical knowledge is required to read this book.

Technology continues to change quickly. New tools and services appear every year. The goal of digital literacy is not only to learn how to use current tools, but also to develop the skills needed to learn and adapt in the future.

We hope this book helps readers feel more confident when using digital technology and encourages thoughtful and responsible use of the internet and digital tools.

Part I

Understanding the Digital World

Chapter 1

What Is Digital Literacy?

Digital technology is now part of everyday life. People use phones, computers, and the internet to communicate, learn, work, shop, and manage many daily tasks. Because of this, it has become important for people to understand how to use digital tools and how to think carefully about the information they see online. This ability is called digital literacy.

Digital literacy is not only about knowing how to use devices. It is also about understanding information, staying safe online, communicating responsibly, and making good decisions when using digital technology.

In this chapter, we explain what digital literacy means, why it matters today, how technology shapes everyday life, and how digital literacy is different from basic computer skills.

1.1 Definition of Digital Literacy

Digital literacy means the ability to use digital devices, software, and the internet in a confident, safe, and responsible way. It includes several related skills.

First, a digitally literate person knows how to use digital tools. This may include using a computer, smartphone, or tablet. It may also include using common software such as web browsers, email, word processors, and messaging apps.

Second, digital literacy includes the ability to find and understand information online. The internet contains a huge amount of information, but not all of it is correct or reliable. A digitally literate person learns how to search for information, compare sources, and decide whether the information is trustworthy.

Third, digital literacy includes communication skills. People communicate online through email (e.g. Gmail and Outlook), social media (e.g. Facebook and Instagram), forums (e.g. Reddit), and messaging platforms (e.g. WhatsApp, Signal and Telegram). Digital literacy means understanding how to communicate clearly and respectfully in these spaces.

Fourth, digital literacy includes safety and responsibility. People need to know how to protect their personal information, recognize scams, avoid harmful websites, and understand how their actions online may affect others.

Finally, digital literacy also includes the ability to create and share digital content. This may include writing documents, making presentations, posting on blogs, sharing photos, or creating videos.

In simple terms, digital literacy means using technology in a thoughtful and responsible way.

1.2 Why Digital Literacy Matters Today

Digital literacy is important because many parts of modern life now depend on digital technology.

Education is one example. Many schools and universities use online learning platforms, digital textbooks, and video lectures. Students often submit assignments online and work with digital tools for research and writing. Without digital literacy, it becomes difficult to participate fully in modern education.

Workplaces also rely heavily on digital technology. Many jobs require people to use email, office software, online collaboration tools, and specialized computer programs. Even jobs that were once mostly physical now often include some digital tasks.

Communication has also changed. Many people stay in touch with friends, family, and coworkers through messaging apps, social media, and video calls. Digital literacy helps people communicate clearly and understand the rules and expectations of online communication.

Government services are increasingly online as well. People may need to access websites to pay taxes, apply for permits, manage benefits, or access public information. Being digitally literate helps people use these services more easily.

Digital literacy is also important for safety. The internet includes scams, misinformation, and harmful content. People who understand how the digital world works are better able to recognize risks and protect themselves.

Because technology is now part of everyday life, digital literacy has become an essential life skill.

1.3 How Technology Shapes Everyday Life

Digital technology influences many small and large parts of daily life.

Many people start their day by checking their phone. They may read messages, look at news, check the weather, or review their schedule. Smartphones have become tools for communication, planning, and entertainment.

Online services also affect how people shop and manage money. People may buy products online, compare prices, read reviews, and use digital payment systems. Banking is often done through mobile apps or websites instead of visiting a physical branch.

Transportation has also changed. People use navigation apps (e.g. Google Maps) to find directions, check traffic, and choose the fastest route. Ride-sharing apps (e.g. Uber) allow people to request transportation with a few taps on their phone.

Entertainment has become largely digital as well. People watch movies through streaming services (e.g. Netflix), listen to music online (e.g. Spotify), and play games on computers and phones. Books, newspapers, and magazines are often read on digital devices (e.g. Kindle).

Work has also changed because of digital technology. Many people work remotely using video meetings, shared documents, and online collaboration tools. Teams may work together even when they are in different cities or countries.

Social life is influenced by technology too. Social media platforms allow people to share photos, ideas, and experiences with others. These platforms can help people stay connected, but they can also spread misinformation or create pressure to compare lives with others.

Because technology touches so many areas of life, understanding how it works has become very important.

1.4 Digital Literacy vs Computer Literacy

The terms digital literacy and computer literacy are sometimes used in similar ways, but they do not mean exactly the same thing.

Computer literacy usually refers to the ability to use a computer and basic software. For example, a computer-literate person may know how to open programs, create documents, send emails, and manage files. These are technical skills related to using a computer.

Digital literacy is a broader concept. It includes computer skills, but it also includes understanding how the digital world works and how to behave responsibly online.

For example, digital literacy includes the ability to evaluate information on the internet. A person should be able to recognize misleading headlines, false information, or unreliable sources.

Digital literacy also includes understanding privacy and security. People should know how to create strong passwords, recognize phishing attempts, and protect personal information.

Another part of digital literacy is understanding digital communication. Online conversations can easily be misunderstood, and messages can spread quickly. Being digitally literate means communicating respectfully and thinking carefully before sharing information.

In short, computer literacy focuses on using computers, while digital literacy focuses on understanding and using the entire digital environment responsibly.

Digital literacy is an important skill for modern life. As technology continues to change, people will need to keep learning and adapting. The goal of digital literacy is not only to use technology effectively, but also to use it thoughtfully, safely, and responsibly.

Chapter 2

Types of Digital Devices

Digital devices are tools that help people work, communicate, learn, and access information. Over the years, these devices have become smaller, faster, and more powerful. Today, people use many different types of digital devices in their daily lives.

Some devices are used mainly for work and study. Others are used for communication, entertainment, or managing everyday tasks. Understanding the different types of devices can help people choose the right tool for their needs.

In this chapter, we will look at some of the most common types of digital devices used today.

2.1 Desktop and Laptop Computers

Desktop and laptop computers are still some of the most powerful and flexible digital devices available.

A desktop computer usually stays in one place, such as on a desk at home or in an office. It normally includes a separate monitor, keyboard, mouse, and a main computer unit. Desktop computers are often used for tasks that need more power, such as programming, video editing, graphic design, scientific work, or gaming.

One advantage of desktop computers is that they can often be upgraded. For example, users can add more memory, install a larger storage drive, or replace components when needed. This can make desktops last longer and perform better for demanding tasks.

A laptop computer is a portable version of a computer. It includes the screen, keyboard, touchpad, and computer hardware in one device. Laptops are designed so people can carry them easily and use them in different places.

Many students and professionals prefer laptops because they can work from home, in a library, in a classroom, or while traveling. Modern laptops are powerful enough to handle most everyday tasks such as writing documents, browsing the internet, attending video meetings, and editing photos.

Both desktops and laptops are widely used in education, research, and professional work. They are often the main device people use when they need to do complex or long tasks.

2.2 Smartphones and Tablets

Smartphones and tablets are portable devices that many people use throughout the day.

A smartphone is a mobile phone that also works as a small computer. It allows people to make calls, send messages, browse the internet, use apps, take photos, and access many online services.

Today, smartphones are one of the most common digital devices in the world. Many people rely on them for everyday activities such as checking email, reading news, watching videos, navigating with maps, or communicating with friends and family.

Smartphones also allow people to install apps, which are small programs designed for specific tasks. Apps can be used for banking, learning languages, managing fitness, shopping online, or connecting with social media platforms.

A tablet is similar to a smartphone but usually has a larger screen. Tablets are often used for reading, watching videos, browsing the web, or taking notes. Some tablets can also connect to keyboards and be used like lightweight laptops.

Tablets are popular in schools, businesses, and homes because they are simple to use and easy to carry. They can be especially useful for activities that benefit from a larger screen, such as reading books, drawing, or viewing documents.

Because smartphones and tablets are portable and always connected to the internet, they have become an important part of modern life.

2.3 Smart Devices and the Internet of Things

In recent years, many everyday objects have become connected to the internet. These are often called smart devices.

Smart devices are part of a larger concept called the Internet of Things, often shortened to IoT. The idea is that many different devices can communicate with each other through the internet.

For example, some homes now include smart devices such as:

- Smart speakers that respond to voice commands (e.g. Alexa)
- Smart lights that can be controlled with a phone
- Smart thermostats that adjust the temperature automatically (e.g. Google Nest)
- Smart security cameras that can be monitored remotely (e.g. Ring and Blink)

People can control many of these devices using smartphone apps or voice assistants.

Smart devices are also used in other areas of life. Fitness trackers (e.g. FitBit) and smart watches (e.g. Apple Watch) monitor physical activity and health information. Smart televisions connect directly to streaming services. Smart appliances, such as refrigerators or washing machines, may send alerts or allow remote control.

In cities and workplaces, smart sensors may be used to manage traffic, monitor energy use, or track equipment.

While smart devices can make life more convenient, they also raise questions about privacy and security. Because these devices collect and share data, it is important for users to understand how their information is being used and protected.

2.4 Choosing the Right Device for Your Needs

Because there are many types of digital devices, it is helpful to think about what tasks you want to perform before choosing one.

If someone needs to do tasks that require more power, such as programming, data analysis, video editing, or professional design work, a desktop or laptop computer may be the best choice.

If someone mainly needs to communicate, browse the internet, use apps, and stay connected while moving around, a smartphone may be the most useful device.

Tablets can be a good choice for people who want a device that is easy to carry and simple to use for reading, watching videos, or taking notes.

Some people use several devices together. For example, a person may use a laptop for work, a smartphone for communication, and smart devices at home for convenience.

When choosing a device, it is also useful to think about factors such as battery life, storage space, screen size, cost, and how long the device will be supported with software updates.

Digital technology continues to change quickly. New devices and new features appear every year. However, the most important goal is not to have the newest device, but to choose tools that help you work, learn, and communicate effectively.

Understanding the different types of digital devices helps people make better choices and use technology in a more thoughtful way.

Part II

Basic Digital Skills

Chapter 3

Operating Systems and File Management

Every digital device needs software that allows it to run programs and manage its hardware. This basic software is called an operating system. The operating system helps users interact with the device, open applications, manage files, and control how the device works.

Understanding operating systems and how files are organized is an important part of digital literacy. When people understand how their devices store information and manage software, they can use technology more effectively and avoid losing important data.

In this chapter, we will look at what operating systems do, some of the most common operating systems used today, how files and folders are organized, and why backups and cloud storage are important.

3.1 What an operating system does

An operating system is the main software that runs on a computer, smartphone, or tablet. It acts as a bridge between the user and the hardware of the device.

When you turn on a device, the operating system starts first. It prepares the system so that other programs can run.

One of the main jobs of an operating system is to manage hardware. Hardware includes parts of the device such as the processor, memory, storage drive, screen, keyboard, camera, and network connection. The operating system makes sure these parts work together properly.

Another important job is running applications. Applications are programs that people use to perform tasks, such as web browsers, text editors, video players, or messaging apps. The operating system allows these programs to start, run, and close.

Operating systems also manage files and storage. They help organize documents, photos, videos, and other files so users can find and use them easily.

Most operating systems provide a graphical interface. This means users can interact with the system using icons, windows, menus, and buttons instead of typing commands. This makes computers easier for many people to use.

Modern operating systems also include security features. They help protect the device from harmful software, control access to files, and manage user accounts.

In simple terms, the operating system is the software that allows a device to function and makes it possible for people to use it.

3.2 Windows, macOS, Linux, Android, and iOS

Different devices use different operating systems. Some operating systems are designed mainly for computers, while others are designed for smartphones and tablets.

Windows is one of the most widely used operating systems for desktop and laptop computers. It is developed by Microsoft and is commonly used in homes, schools, and businesses. Many software programs and games are designed to work on Windows.

macOS is the operating system used on Apple computers such as MacBooks and iMacs. It is designed to work closely with Apple hardware and is known for its clean design and integration with other Apple devices.

Linux is another operating system used on computers. Unlike Windows and macOS, Linux is open source. This means its code is publicly available and many different groups and communities contribute to its development. Linux is widely used on servers and by developers, but there are also versions designed for everyday computer users.

Android is one of the most common operating systems used on smartphones and tablets. It is developed mainly by Google and is used by many different phone manufacturers. Android allows users to install apps from online stores and customize many parts of the device.

iOS is the operating system used on Apple's iPhones. A related system called iPadOS is used on iPads. These systems are designed to work smoothly with Apple hardware and services.

Although these operating systems look different and have different features, they all perform similar basic tasks. They run applications, manage hardware, organize files, and provide ways for users to interact with their devices.

3.3 Files, folders, and storage

Digital devices store information in the form of files. A file is a unit of information stored on a device. Examples of files include documents, photos, videos, music, and programs.

Files usually have names and often include an extension that describes the file type. For example, a document might end with .txt or .docx, while a photo might end with .jpg or .png.

To keep files organized, operating systems use folders. A folder is a container that holds files and sometimes other folders. This structure helps users group related files together.

For example, a person might have a folder called Work that contains documents related to their job. Inside that folder, there might be smaller folders for projects, reports, or meetings.

This system is sometimes called a directory structure. It helps users find files quickly and keep their data organized.

Files are stored on storage devices such as hard drives, solid-state drives, memory cards, or internal phone storage. The amount of storage determines how much information a device can hold.

Some files take up more space than others. Videos and high-resolution photos usually require more storage than simple text documents.

Learning how to organize files and folders is an important skill. It helps people keep their digital information easy to find and manage.

3.4 Backups and cloud storage

Digital information can sometimes be lost. Devices may fail, files may be deleted by accident, or software problems may occur. Because of this, it is important to create backups.

A backup is a copy of important data stored in another location. If the original files are lost or damaged, the backup can be used to restore them.

One common way to create backups is by copying files to an external storage device, such as an external hard drive or a USB drive.

Another common method is cloud storage. Cloud storage means that files are stored on remote servers that are accessed through the internet.

Many services offer cloud storage, allowing users to save files online and access them from different devices. For example, a person may create a document on a laptop and later open the same document on a phone or tablet.

Cloud storage also provides an extra level of protection. If a device is lost or damaged, the files stored in the cloud can still be accessed.

However, users should still think carefully about security and privacy when using cloud services. It is important to use strong passwords and choose services that protect user data.

Creating regular backups and using cloud storage wisely can help prevent the loss of important digital information.

Understanding operating systems and file management helps people use digital devices more effectively and safely. These skills make it easier to organize information, protect important files, and solve common problems when using technology.

Chapter 4

Using the Internet

The internet is one of the most important tools in modern life. People use it to communicate, learn, work, shop, watch videos, read news, and share information. Many everyday services now depend on the internet.

To use the internet effectively, it is helpful to understand how it works and how to find information online. People also need to understand how websites are organized and how to recognize reliable sources of information.

In this chapter, we will look at how the internet works, how web browsers and search engines help people explore the web, how to search for information more effectively, and how to understand website addresses and links.

4.1 How the internet works

The internet is a global network of computers and devices connected to each other. These devices communicate using common technical rules called protocols. These rules allow information to travel from one device to another across many networks.

When a person connects to the internet, their device usually connects through an internet service provider. This provider may be a home broadband company, a mobile network, or a public network such as a university or library.

Information on the internet travels in small pieces called data packets. These packets move across many computers and network systems until they reach their destination.

For example, when you open a website, your device sends a request to a server. A server is a computer that stores websites and other online services. The server responds by sending the requested information back to your device. Your web browser then displays the webpage on your screen.

The internet includes many different services, such as websites, email systems, video streaming services, and online communication platforms. Even though these services look different to users, they all rely on the same underlying network connections.

Because the internet connects millions of computers around the world, it allows people to access information and communicate across long distances almost instantly.

4.2 Web browsers and search engines

To access information on the internet, people usually use a program called a web browser.

A web browser is software that allows users to view and interact with websites. When a person enters a website address into the browser, the browser requests the webpage from the server and displays it on the screen.

Common web browsers include Chrome, Firefox, Safari, and Edge. Although they may look slightly different, they all perform the same basic functions. They allow users to visit websites, follow links, download files, and interact with online services.

Search engines are tools that help people find information on the web. Because there are billions of webpages online, it would be very difficult to find useful information without search tools.

A search engine works by indexing webpages across the internet. It collects information about many websites and stores this information in a large database.

When a user types a search query into a search engine, the system looks through its index and returns a list of results that are related to the search terms.

Popular search engines include Google, Bing, and DuckDuckGo. Each search engine uses its own methods to rank and display results.

Search engines make it possible to quickly find information, websites, images, videos, and many other types of content.

4.3 How to search effectively

Searching the internet is easy, but finding the most useful information sometimes requires better search strategies.

One important step is choosing clear and specific keywords. Instead of typing a long question, it is often better to search using a few important words that describe the topic.

For example, instead of searching for a full sentence such as “How do I grow tomatoes in a small garden,” a user might search for “growing tomatoes small garden tips.”

Another useful method is refining the search if the first results are not helpful. Users can try different words, add more details, or remove words that may be confusing the search engine.

Search engines also allow users to place quotation marks around phrases to search for exact matches. This can help when looking for specific titles, quotes, or names.

Users should also look at several search results instead of only the first one. Sometimes useful information appears further down the list.

It is also important to think about the reliability of the source. Not every webpage contains accurate information. Good sources often include educational institutions, government organizations, established publications, or well-known experts.

Developing good search habits helps people find better information and avoid misleading content.

4.4 Understanding websites and URLs

Every webpage on the internet has a unique address called a URL. URL stands for Uniform Resource Locator. It tells the browser where to find a specific resource on the internet.

A typical URL has several parts.

The first part usually shows the protocol, such as http or https. The https version indicates that the connection between the browser and the website is encrypted, which provides better security.

The next part is the domain name. The domain name identifies the website. For example, in the address https://example.com, the domain name is example.com.

Many websites also include additional paths after the domain name. These paths show the location of a specific page or file on the website.

For example, a URL might look like this:

https://example.com/articles/digital-literacy

In this case, the page is located inside a section called articles on the example.com website.

Understanding URLs can help users recognize where information is coming from. For example, a website ending in .gov often belongs to a government organization, while .edu usually belongs to an educational institution.

However, users should still evaluate websites carefully. A professional-looking webpage does not always guarantee accurate information.

Learning how websites and URLs work helps users navigate the internet more confidently and understand where online information comes from.

Using the internet effectively is an important part of digital literacy. By understanding how the internet works, how to search for information, and how to interpret website addresses, people can explore the online world more safely and efficiently.

Chapter 5

Communication Online

Digital technology has changed the way people communicate. In the past, most communication happened through face-to-face conversations, phone calls, or letters. Today, many conversations happen online through email, messaging apps, social media, and video calls.

Online communication allows people to stay connected across long distances. It also allows people to share information quickly and work together even when they are not in the same place.

However, communicating online also requires some care. Messages can sometimes be misunderstood, and information can spread very quickly. Learning how to communicate clearly and respectfully online is an important part of digital literacy.

In this chapter, we will look at the basics of email, messaging apps and video calls, online etiquette, and how to manage digital communication effectively.

5.1 Email basics

Email is one of the oldest and most widely used forms of online communication. It allows people to send messages and files over the internet.

An email message usually includes several parts. The first part is the recipient's address. This tells the system where the message should be delivered. Email addresses usually follow a format such as name@example.com.

The next part is the subject line. The subject line briefly describes what the email is about. A clear subject line helps the reader understand the purpose of the message.

The main section of the email is the message body. This is where the sender writes the actual message. In many cases, emails are written in a simple and polite style.

Emails may also include attachments. Attachments are files that are sent together with the email. These can include documents, photos, or other types of files.

Email is commonly used for professional communication, school communication, and formal messages. Because of this, it is helpful to write emails clearly and politely.

Good email habits include writing a clear subject line, keeping the message organized, and checking for mistakes before sending.

5.2 Messaging apps and video calls

In addition to email, many people communicate using messaging apps. These apps allow people to send short messages quickly using smartphones, tablets, or computers.

Messaging apps often support text messages, voice messages, photos, videos, and file sharing. Many apps also allow group conversations where several people can communicate together.

Examples of messaging platforms include SMS messaging, instant messaging services, and social media messaging systems.

Messaging apps are often used for quick and informal communication. People may use them to talk with friends, family members, coworkers, or classmates.

Video calls are another common form of digital communication. Video calling allows people to see and hear each other in real time using cameras and microphones.

Video calls are widely used for remote work, online classes, meetings, and conversations with friends or family who live far away.

Good video call habits include joining the meeting on time, checking that the microphone and camera are working, and speaking clearly so others can understand.

Because messaging apps and video calls allow fast communication, they have become an important part of everyday digital life.

5.3 Online etiquette (netiquette)

Just like in face-to-face communication, it is important to be respectful when communicating online. The basic rules of polite online behavior are often called netiquette.

One important rule is to be clear and respectful in messages. Because people cannot see facial expressions or body language online, messages may sometimes be misunderstood. Writing clearly and avoiding harsh language can help prevent confusion.

Another important rule is to think before posting or sending a message. Once information is shared online, it may be difficult to remove completely.

It is also important to respect other people's privacy. Personal information, photos, or messages should not be shared without permission.

In group conversations, it is helpful to stay on topic and avoid sending too many unnecessary messages. This helps keep communication organized and respectful for everyone involved.

Using polite language, avoiding arguments, and respecting different opinions can make online communities more positive and productive.

Good online behavior helps build trust and makes communication more effective.

5.4 Managing digital communication

Modern technology allows people to receive messages from many different platforms. Email, messaging apps, social media, and workplace tools can all send notifications throughout the day.

While this constant communication can be useful, it can also become overwhelming if it is not managed carefully.

One useful habit is organizing email messages into folders or categories. This helps people separate work messages, personal messages, and less important emails.

Another helpful practice is turning off unnecessary notifications. Too many alerts can interrupt work and reduce concentration.

Some people also set specific times during the day to check messages instead of responding to every notification immediately.

It is also important to recognize that not every message requires an instant reply. Taking time to think before responding can often lead to clearer communication.

Managing digital communication effectively helps people stay organized, reduce stress, and focus on important tasks.

Online communication has become an essential part of modern life. By understanding how different communication tools work and following good online practices, people can communicate more clearly, respectfully, and responsibly in the digital world.

Part III

Finding and Evaluating Information

Chapter 6

Searching for Reliable Information

6.1 Search techniques

6.2 Using advanced search tools

6.3 Finding academic or trustworthy sources

Chapter 7

Misinformation and Fake News

7.1 What misinformation is

7.2 Why false information spreads

7.3 How to verify information

7.4 Fact-checking tools

Chapter 8

Understanding Digital Media

8.1 Images, videos, and audio online

8.2 Manipulated media and deepfakes

8.3 Advertising and sponsored content

Part IV

Online Safety and Privacy

Chapter 9

Protecting Your Personal Information

9.1 What personal data is

9.2 How companies collect data

9.3 Privacy settings and permissions

Chapter 10

Passwords and Account Security

10.1 Creating strong passwords

10.2 Password managers

10.3 Two-factor authentication

10.4 Recognizing suspicious login activity

Chapter 11

Protecting Your Personal Information

11.1 What personal data is

11.2 How companies collect data

11.3 Privacy settings and permissions

Part V

Digital Citizenship

Chapter 12

Responsible Behavior Online

12.1 Respectful communication

12.2 Cyberbullying and harassment

12.3 Managing digital conflicts

Chapter 13

Digital Footprints

13.1 What a digital footprint is?

13.2 How online posts stay online

13.3 Managing your online reputation

Chapter 14

Copyright and Creative Commons

14.1 Ownership of digital content

14.2 Using images, text, and media legally

14.3 Open licenses and sharing knowledge

Part VI

Creating Digital Content

Chapter 15

Writing and Publishing Online

15.1 Blogs and websites

15.2 Basic formatting and structure

15.3 Responsible publishing

Chapter 16

Working With Digital Media

16.1 Creating images and videos

16.2 Basic editing tools

16.3 Sharing media responsibly

Chapter 17

Collaboration in the Digital World

17.1 Online collaboration tools

17.2 Shared documents and version control

17.3 Working with remote teams

Part VII

Digital Skills for Work and Learning

Chapter 18

Productivity Tools

18.1 Documents, spreadsheets, and presentations

18.2 Online learning platforms

18.3 Task management tools

Chapter 19

Using Technology for Lifelong Learning

19.1 Online courses and tutorials

19.2 Learning communities

19.3 Building new skills online

Part VIII

The Future of the Digital World

Chapter 20

Artificial Intelligence and Automation

20.1 What AI is

20.2 Everyday uses of AI

20.3 Opportunities and risks

Chapter 21

Ethical Use of Technology

21.1 Bias in algorithms

21.2 Responsible AI use

21.3 Technology and society

Chapter 22

Staying Digitally Literate

22.1 Adapting to new technologies

22.2 Continuous learning habits

22.3 Teaching digital literacy to others

Appendix A

GitHub Contributors

This page was generated automatically from the GitHub repository `openhandbookcommons/ohc-001-digital-literacy` at render time.

Contributor	GitHub	Contributions
rohitfarmer	profile	9

Index

Digital literacy, 8